Kitchen *& Kettle*

Egg Preservation Guide

THREE METHODS. ZERO WASTE. EGGS WHEN YOU NEED THEM.

What to do when you have more eggs than you can eat — freezing for baking, water glassing for long-term storage, and pickling for ready-to-eat protein. No special equipment required.

Handling Farm Fresh Eggs

Before you preserve anything, it helps to understand how a fresh egg actually works. Farm eggs are different from supermarket eggs — and knowing the difference changes how you store, wash, and use them.

THE BLOOM

A freshly laid egg has an invisible coating called the bloom — a protective seal the hen deposits as the egg leaves her body. It plugs the microscopic pores in the shell, keeping bacteria out and moisture in. As long as the bloom is intact, the egg is sealed.

Supermarket eggs have already been washed — the bloom is gone. That's why they must stay refrigerated. Farm eggs with intact bloom can sit on your counter for weeks. No refrigeration needed. This is how most of the world stores eggs.

STORAGE

WHERE	UNWASHED (BLOOM INTACT)	WASHED (BLOOM REMOVED)
Counter	2–3 weeks	Do not store on counter
Refrigerator	Up to 3 months	About 2 months

THE ONE RULE

If the egg stays whole

DO NOT WASH

The bloom protects it. Washing removes that protection. For water glassing and fresh storage, keep them unwashed.

If you're cracking or boiling

WASH FIRST

Wash just before use — not before storage. For freezing and pickling, wash right before you crack or boil the eggs.

THE FLOAT TEST

Not sure if an egg is still good? Fill a bowl with cool water and gently place the egg in.

Sinks flat	Stands upright	Floats
Fresh	**Still good**	**Discard**
Use for anything — fry, poach, bake, preserve.	Use soon — best for baking or hard boiling.	Gas has built up inside. Not worth the risk — compost it.

Which method when?

You don't have to learn all three. Pick based on what you need.

METHOD	BEST FOR	SHELF LIFE	EQUIPMENT	EFFORT
Freezing	Baking, scrambled eggs, quiche	6–12 months	Ice cube tray or muffin tin, freezer bags	Low
Water glassing	Long-term backup, no electricity needed	8–12 months at room temp	Food-grade bucket or jar, pickling lime	Very low
Pickling	Ready-to-eat snacks, salads, charcuterie	3–4 months refrigerated	Quart jar, saucepan	Medium

The simple system

When you collect eggs each day, sort them into three piles:

1. **Perfect, clean, fresh eggs** → water glass. These are your long-term backup.
2. **Extra eggs beyond what you'll eat this week** → freeze. These become your baking supply.
3. **Older eggs, or you want grab-and-eat protein** → pickle. These live in the fridge, ready when you are.

No stress. No waste. You don't have to do all three — even one method changes how your kitchen works.

Mistakes to avoid

Don't wash eggs before water glassing. Don't freeze eggs in the shell (they'll crack). Don't use dirty or cracked eggs for any preservation method. Don't store pickled eggs at room temperature — they must stay refrigerated.

Method 1: Freezing Eggs

This is your baking supply. Frozen eggs work exactly like fresh in cakes, muffins, quiche, and most cooked dishes. They're less reliable for things that depend on egg structure — meringues, soufflés, angel food cake — but for everyday baking, they're indistinguishable.

WHAT YOU NEED

- Fresh eggs
- Bowl + whisk or fork
- Ice cube tray or muffin tin
- Freezer bags
- Tiny pinch of salt (savory use) *or* sugar (sweet use)

STEPS

1. Wash eggs (you're cracking them, so bloom doesn't matter).
2. Crack eggs into a bowl.
3. Gently whisk just until yolks and whites are combined — don't whip air into them.
4. Add a tiny pinch of salt per egg (for savory cooking) or sugar (for baking). This prevents the yolks from turning grainy in the freezer.
5. Pour into ice cube trays — about 1 egg per cube slot. For muffin tins, 1–2 eggs per cup.
6. Freeze until solid (4–6 hours).
7. Pop cubes out and transfer to a labeled freezer bag.

HOW TO USE

Thaw overnight in the refrigerator.
Use exactly like fresh eggs in baking.
1 cube ≈ 1 egg (label your bag).

Quick reference

Whole eggs (whisked)	1 egg = 1 cube
Whites only	Freeze as-is, no whisking needed
Yolks only	Add ⅛ tsp salt or ½ tsp sugar per yolk before freezing

HONEST NOTE

Frozen eggs won't make a perfect fried egg. The texture changes slightly — they're best in anything where eggs are mixed in: baking, scrambles, quiche, French toast. If you want a runny yolk on toast, use fresh eggs.

LABELING MATTERS

Write on every bag: the date, how many eggs, and whether you added salt or sugar. Frozen egg cubes all look the same. Six months from now, you won't remember.

Method 2: Water Glassing

This is your homestead insurance. No electricity, no canning, no sealing — just eggs, water, and pickling lime (calcium hydroxide). The eggs stay raw and room-temperature-stable for 8–12 months. When you crack them, they cook like fresh eggs. This is the method people used before refrigeration, and it still works.

WHAT YOU NEED

Fresh, unwashed eggs — same day is ideal, must have intact bloom

Food-grade bucket or large glass jar

Pickling lime (calcium hydroxide) — hardware store or grocery canning section

Water (room temperature, distilled preferred but not required)

The ratio

1 quart (4 cups) water : 1 ounce (2 tablespoons) pickling lime

You don't need to be exact — close enough works. Scale up for larger containers: a gallon of water gets about 4 ounces of lime.

STEPS

1. Mix pickling lime into room-temperature water. Stir until dissolved (the water will look milky — that's normal).
2. Gently place unwashed eggs into your container. Pointy side down if possible — the air cell is at the round end and they store better this way.
3. Pour lime solution over the eggs until they're fully covered by at least 1–2 inches of liquid.
4. Cover loosely — a lid resting on top (not sealed) or a cloth secured with a rubber band. The container needs to breathe slightly.
5. Store in a cool, dark place — basement, pantry, cool closet. Aim for 50–60°F if possible, but room temperature works.
6. Check occasionally. If water evaporates and eggs are exposed, top up with fresh lime solution.

HOW TO USE

1. Remove eggs as needed — use clean hands or a spoon.
2. Rinse the egg well under cool water before cracking.
3. Use exactly like fresh eggs — fry, scramble, bake, poach.

Reality check

The whites will be slightly thinner than fresh eggs after long storage. This matters for fancy meringues but not for everyday cooking. Yolks may also be a bit more fragile — break them into a separate bowl first if you need intact yolks.

HONEST NOTE

Water glassing is the lowest-effort method in this guide, but it requires the freshest eggs. If you're buying supermarket eggs, skip this — the bloom is already washed off. This method is for backyard hens, farmers market eggs you know are unwashed, or any source where you can confirm the eggs still have their natural coating. And yes, the lime water looks unappetizing. The eggs inside are fine.

Method 3: Pickled Eggs

This is your grab-and-eat protein. Pickled eggs are a pub tradition for a reason — they're satisfying, portable, and get better with time. They live in the fridge, not the cupboard, and they're ready whenever you are.

WHAT YOU NEED

- Hard-boiled eggs (older eggs peel easier)
- White vinegar or cider vinegar
- Water
- Salt
- Quart jar with lid
- Optional: garlic cloves, peppercorns, fresh dill, bay leaf, sliced chili, beet juice

Basic brine

Vinegar	1 cup
Water	1 cup
Salt	1 tablespoon

Makes enough brine for about 6–8 eggs in a quart jar.

STEPS

1. Hard boil and peel your eggs. (Older eggs peel more cleanly — if your eggs are very fresh, add a splash of vinegar to the boiling water.)
2. Pack peeled eggs into a clean quart jar. Don't cram them — leave a little space so brine can surround each egg.
3. Add your aromatics: garlic, peppercorns, dill, chili — whatever sounds good.
4. Bring brine ingredients to a boil. Stir until salt dissolves.
5. Pour hot brine over eggs until they're fully covered.
6. Let cool on the counter, then seal and refrigerate.
7. **Wait.** Minimum 1 week before eating. Better at 2–3 weeks when the flavor has penetrated all the way through.

THREE VARIATIONS

Garlic + dill
The classic. 2 garlic cloves + a few sprigs of fresh dill + 1 tsp black peppercorns. Use cider vinegar for warmth.

Beet + sweet
Add ¼ cup beet juice (from canned beets) to the brine + 1 tbsp sugar. Turns the eggs bright pink and slightly sweet. Stunning on a plate.

Spicy
Add 2 sliced jalapeños or 1 tsp red chili flakes + 1 bay leaf + 1 tsp mustard seeds. Use white vinegar. Gets hotter over time.

Important

- Always refrigerate pickled eggs — they are not shelf-stable.
- Keep eggs fully submerged in brine. Exposed eggs risk spoilage.
- Don't reuse brine for a second batch — start fresh.
- Shelf life: 3–4 months in the fridge.

Serving ideas

- Halved on a salad with sturdy greens
- On a cheese board with sharp cheddar and mustard
- Sliced on buttered dark bread with salt
- Straight from the jar at midnight (it happens)

Emptying the Nest Box

When you're drowning in eggs — and your freezer bags and water-glassing bucket are already full — these are the recipes that use them up fast. Each one eats a lot of eggs, freezes well, or pairs naturally with preserved eggs.

Frittata or Spanish Tortilla

Uses 6–8 eggs · Freezes in slices · Any meal of the day

You need: 6–8 eggs · 2 tbsp butter or oil · 2 cups chopped vegetables or cooked meat · ½ tsp salt · pinch of pepper

Heat butter in an oven-safe skillet over medium heat. Sauté vegetables or meat until soft, about 5 minutes. Beat eggs with salt and pepper, pour over the fillings, and cook without stirring until the edges set — about 5 minutes. Transfer to a 375°F oven for 10–15 minutes until the center is just firm. Spanish tortilla: thinly slice 2 medium potatoes, cook in ¼ cup oil until tender, pour beaten eggs over, cook low and slow, flip onto a plate. Both eat well cold and reheat perfectly.

Preserved eggs? Frozen eggs work beautifully here — thaw overnight and use as-is. Water-glassed eggs fry up indistinguishable from fresh.

Quiche

Uses 4–6 eggs · Freezes whole or in slices · Feeds a crowd

You need: 4–6 eggs · 2–3 cups cream or milk (½ cup per egg) · 1½ cups fillings (greens, bacon, cheese) · 1 unbaked pie crust · ½ tsp salt · pinch of nutmeg (optional)

Scatter fillings in the crust. Whisk eggs, cream, salt, and nutmeg together, pour over the fillings. Bake at 375°F for 35–45 minutes until the center barely jiggles. Cool 10 minutes before slicing. Freeze baked quiche wrapped in foil — reheat from frozen at 350°F for 20–25 minutes.

Preserved eggs? Frozen eggs are ideal — the texture difference disappears in custard.

Curd uses yolks. Save the whites for angel food cake. Zero waste. Two desserts from one glut.

Emptying the Nest Box (continued)

Homemade Pasta

Uses 4+ eggs per batch · Dries or freezes · No special equipment

You need (for 4 eggs): 4 eggs · 3 cups all-purpose flour · 1 tsp salt

Mound flour on a clean counter, make a well in the center. Crack eggs into the well, add salt. Beat eggs with a fork, slowly pulling in flour from the walls. Once a shaggy dough forms, knead 8–10 minutes until smooth and elastic. Wrap in plastic and rest 30 minutes. Roll thin with a rolling pin (or pasta machine), cut into noodles, and dry on a rack or freeze in nests. Cooks in 2–3 minutes in boiling salted water.

Preserved eggs? Fresh or water-glassed eggs work best — the structure matters here. Frozen eggs are fine but add a few drops less liquid.

Lemon Curd

Uses 6+ yolks · Keeps 3–4 weeks in the fridge · Also freezes

You need: 6 egg yolks · 1 cup sugar · ½ cup lemon juice (2–3 lemons) · ½ cup butter (1 stick), cut into pieces

Whisk yolks, sugar, and lemon juice together in a heatproof bowl set over a pot of simmering water (don't let the bowl touch the water). Stir constantly with a spatula until the mixture thickens and coats the back of a spoon — about 8–10 minutes. Remove from heat, stir in butter piece by piece until smooth. Strain into a jar, cool, and refrigerate. Spoon it on toast, scones, yogurt, or eat it straight from the jar.

Preserved eggs? Use fresh yolks if possible — frozen yolks can sometimes stay slightly grainy even after thawing. But in a pinch, they'll work.

Emptying the Nest Box (cont.)

Angel Food Cake

Uses 12 egg whites · The companion to lemon curd · Freezes beautifully

You need: 12 egg whites (room temperature) · 1½ cups sugar · 1 cup cake flour or all-purpose flour · 1½ tsp cream of tartar · 1½ tsp vanilla extract · ¼ tsp salt

Sift flour and ¾ cup of the sugar together. Beat egg whites with cream of tartar and salt until foamy, then gradually add the remaining ¾ cup sugar. Beat to stiff, glossy peaks. Fold in vanilla, then gently fold in the flour-sugar mixture in thirds — don't overmix. Spoon into an ungreased tube pan, smooth the top. Bake at 350°F for 35–40 minutes until golden and springy. Invert the pan immediately (it has little feet for this) and cool completely upside down. Light, cloudlike, and every bit of it uses up the whites from your curd session.

Preserved eggs? Frozen whites work perfectly here — they whip up the same as fresh. Separate them before freezing (no whisking needed, unlike whole eggs).

Breakfast Burritos

Uses 1 egg per burrito · Freeze individually · Grab-and-go breakfast

Per burrito: 1 egg · ¼ cup cooked beans · 2 tbsp shredded cheese · ¼ cup cooked potatoes · 1 flour tortilla · salsa to taste

Scramble eggs, warm beans and potatoes. Fill each tortilla with eggs, beans, cheese, and potatoes. Add salsa, roll tightly, wrap in foil. Freeze in a single layer. To reheat: microwave 1 minute, flip, 1 more minute. Make a dozen on a Sunday and you've got breakfast for two weeks.

Preserved eggs? Frozen eggs were made for this. Thaw a bag of egg cubes, scramble, and nobody will know they weren't cracked five minutes ago.

Pickled Egg Salad

Uses 3–4 pickled eggs · No cooking · 5 minutes

You need: 3–4 pickled eggs · 2–3 tbsp mayonnaise · ½ tsp mustard · salt and pepper to taste

Chop the eggs, mix with mayo and mustard. Add salt and pepper. The brine already seasoned the eggs — you'll need less mayo than ordinary egg salad. Spoon onto bread or scoop with crackers. Bright, tangy, and completely different.

Tip: Beet-pickled eggs make a shocking pink egg salad. Great conversation starter at a potluck.

Bread Pudding (Savory or Sweet)

Uses 4–6 eggs · Uses up stale bread too · Freezes in portions

You need: 4–6 eggs · 2 cups milk · 4 cups cubed stale bread · ½ tsp salt

For sweet: add ½ cup sugar, 1 tsp cinnamon, ½ cup raisins or dried fruit, 1 tsp vanilla. **For savory:** add 1 cup shredded cheese, 2 tbsp fresh herbs, black pepper.

Cube the bread, toss with your mix-ins in a buttered baking dish. Whisk eggs, milk, and salt together, pour over the bread. Press down gently so every piece soaks. Let sit 15 minutes. Bake at 350°F for 35–45 minutes until puffed and golden. It's the original waste-nothing dish — stale bread and a glut of eggs, together at last.

Preserved eggs? Any preserved form works. This dish is beyond forgiving.

HONEST NOTE

You will not get through all of these in one season. Pick two that sound good and get comfortable with them. A frittata and a batch of lemon curd will clear more eggs than you think — and both freeze. The rest are here when you need them.

A note on scale

You don't need a flock of hens to use this guide. Even a dozen extra eggs from a neighbor or a good farmers market find is worth preserving. One jar of pickled eggs. One freezer bag of egg cubes. One small bucket of water-glassed eggs.

The point isn't volume. The point is that your kitchen can handle abundance when it shows up — whether that's three eggs or three dozen.

Works because it works.

NOTES

What you made, what worked, what you'd change next time.

Kitchen & Kettle

A quieter way to run a kitchen.